Now, much to his chagrin, Shinde finds his old albatross weighing down on him again. The NCP insisted on key departments like finance, and sources say they were given a commitment on this by the BJP central leadership. Shinde's Sena resisted and portfolio allocation was therefore delayed for almost two weeks. But it was futile. When the new line-up was announced on July 14, it was clear Shinde had had to sign off on his own defeat: the NCP had had its way, walking away with plum departments like finance, cooperation, food and civil supplies and medical education. Two Shinde ministers, Sanjay Rathod and Abdul Sattar, in the BJP's cross-hairs for their style of functioning and for being magnets for controversies, got shunted to lesser departments. Other Shinde men, after waiting for months for a cabinet expansion, had the mortification of seeing their new NCP colleagues get the cream. And 14 departments, some of which they had been eyeing, were left fallow.

Muddying the waters further, the disqualification proceedings pending from last year have come back to life. On July 8, six days after Ajit came on board, Maharashtra speaker Rahul Narwekar issued notices to MLAs of both Sena factions, seeking replies on their petitions against each other. That gave grist to speculation, voiced by those like former CM and senior Congress leader Prithviraj Chavan, that Ajit may eventually replace Shinde at the helm of the state.

In short, Shinde seems to be in power, but not in authority. A stark reality check for a man who was flexing his muscles just weeks ago, with his followers issuing advertisements claiming he was more popular than Fadnavis. Overall, he looks under siege from all sides—from the BJP, from an edgy NCP splinter stuck into his side more like a thorn than a shield, and from his own increasingly restive band. MLA Bacchu Kadu, whose Prahar Janshakti Party has two legislators, admitted to the discontent in the ruling camp. The mercurial Kadu, who was a minister of state in the MVA government, had joined Shinde and is still awaiting his rehabilitation in the council of ministers.

SHINDE IN A CORNER

- Shinde and his men had cited the domineering attitude of Ajit Pawar as deputy CM and finance minister in the MVA government as one reason for their rebellion. The Shiv Sena was being cornered by the NCP, they said. Now, they find their former bugbears on the same side as them once again
- The Sena and NCP compete for political space in many parts of Maharashtra. This was one of the incongruences in the MVA alliance. Shinde has to deal with the same dilemma now
- Ajit Pawar getting the finance department means he'll control the government's purse strings
- The NCP's breakaway faction is seen as being on a stronger footing than Shinde's Sena. This may lead to Ajit Pawar's men getting favourable terms from the BJP
- Ajit is seen as more of an aggressive go-getter and better administrator than Shinde

WITH AJIT PAWAR'S ENTRY INTO THE GOVT, CM SHINDE APPEARS TO BE UNDER SIEGE—FROM THE BJP, NCP AND HIS RESTIVE MLAs

The Sena and the NCP have always competed for political space in parts of Maharashtra like Konkan and Marathwada, a bone of contention even during the MVA's rule. The bitterness has been inherited by the new offspring factions. Bharatshet Gogawale, the Sena MLA from Mahad in Raigad, has upped the ante against the likelihood of the NCP's Aditi Tatkare being made the district's guardian minister. Like the two other Sena MLAs from Raigad who joined Shinde's rebellion in 2021, Gogawale was at odds with Aditi and her father Sunil Tatkare, Raigad MP and close Ajit aide. Before Aditi took her oath as the first woman minister in the Shinde cabinet, Gogawale was also in contention for a ministerial berth and the charge of the Raigad district.

"Things are under control, but there is discontent," admits a Shinde faction Lok Sabha MP. "Of the 50 MLAs with us (including 10 Independents), a few are restive as our share of power has reduced because of the Ajit faction joining the government." An internecine clash over portfolios within the breakaway NCP itself, the grapevine suggests, may have been political *'noora kushti'*, a mock conflict aimed at resisting the pressure for a cabinet expansion. As for the Uddhav camp, a loyalist MP says Shinde's perceived marginalisation helps their side as it will stem further defections. The Shinde camp had otherwise been able to continue procuring some high-profile crossovers till just before the cabinet expansion, like that of state legislative council deputy chairperson Dr Neelam Gorhe on July 2.

BJP leaders say the decision to bring Ajit Pawar on board was prompted by the need to ensure a good show in the 2024 Lok Sabha election. In 2019, the BJP and the undivided Sena had secured 41 of Maharashtra's 48 seats and the question was how to repeat this after Uddhav 's departure from the NDA. As far as the BJP was concerned, Shinde's rebellion was good to weaken the mutinous Uddhav but he looked to be offering no guarantee of getting Sena cadres, or votes, to shift en masse from the Thackeray side. Ajit's NCP cohort, by contrast, are sub-regional satraps who have the capacity to transfer the benefits of their strong ground base to BJP nominees. The BJP has also announced its intent to win over 152 of the 288 assembly seats in Maharashtra, while Ajit has told his men they will fight from 90 seats. This leads to a pertinent question—how many seats will Shinde's party get to contest?

A senior BJP MLA admits to the unrest in the Shinde camp but says their "nuisance value" has been successfully "circumscribed". His words, however, seem to leave open a key utility value for